

# Tribal India — Ethnicity, Rebellions, Regionalism & LWE

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## 1 Ethnicity — Concept and Perspectives

### Definition

**Ethnicity** (broader sense): Self-consciousness of a group of people united, or closely related, by shared experience — such as language, religious belief, common heritage, etc.

In simple terms: refers to a common ancestral, social and cultural experience; more often identifies with **race, region, religion, language** and other cultural elements.

### Six Connotations of Ethnicity

**John Hutchinson & Anthony D. Smith** identified six defining connotations of ethnicity:

1. Shares a common **name**
2. A myth of common **ancestry**
3. **Memories** of common past
4. Elements of a common **culture — religion, custom & language**
5. A link with a homeland or **region**
6. A sense of **solidarity**

## Three Perspectives to Study Ethnicity

| Perspective                            | Scholars                                    | Core Idea                                                                                                                                                                                    | Criticism                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|----------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>1. Primordial Approach</b>          | Edward Shils (1957); Clifford Geertz (1961) | Ethnic identity is <i>innate</i> — we are born with it. Based on deep emotional ties: blood, religion, language, culture. Conflict arises when identity is threatened.                       | Humans do not have only one identity. Even within one language group, people differ in accent, customs, and beliefs.                                                                                      |
| <b>2. Instrumentalist Approach</b>     | Paul Brass (1991); Ted Gurr; Abner Cohen    | Ethnic identity is <i>not natural</i> — it is constructed and used by elites (politicians, religious leaders, teachers) to gain power, resources, or influence. Ethnicity is a <i>tool</i> . | Assumes people are easily manipulated; in reality, people hold strong cultural attachments that cannot always be shaped for political gain.                                                               |
| <b>3. Situated Primordial Approach</b> | Carsten Wieland                             | <i>Combines both</i> views — identity is partly innate (primordial) and partly shaped/activated by elites (instrumentalist). Deep emotional bond exists, but leaders can mobilise it.        | Primordial view fails to explain <i>how</i> shared identity turns into group mobilisation; instrumentalist fails to explain <i>why</i> people respond. Situated primordial offers a more balanced answer. |

## Conclusion on Ethnicity

Ethnic identity shapes how individuals connect with community and distinguish themselves from others. It gives people a **sense of belonging** but can become a **source of division** when politicised. In India, ethnicity is one of the major challenges for the nation-state — visible in autonomy demands, secessionist movements, insurgencies, and ethnic conflicts. Balancing **unity with cultural diversity** is essential for national integration.

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## 2 Ethnic Conflicts & Political Developments

### Definition of Ethnic Conflict

An **ethnic conflict** is a conflict between two or more contending ethnic groups. The source may be political, social, economic, or religious — but individuals must expressly fight for their ethnic group's position within society.

### Colonial Context

- During colonial period, tribal land was exposed to outsiders — moneylenders and local landlords encroached on tribal lands.
- Exploitation pushed tribals into extreme poverty → anger and discontent → **rebellion**.

### Surajit Sinha's Five Types of Tribal Movements (1972)

Surajit Sinha (1972) classified tribal movements into five types:

| # | Type                                                             | Description                                                                                    | Examples                                                                                        |
|---|------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 | <b>Ethnic Rebellious Movements</b>                               | Armed rebellions during British rule in 18th–19th centuries; response to colonial exploitation | Birsa Munda movement; Kol Rebellion (1832); Santhal Rebellion (1857–58); Naga Rebellion (1880s) |
| 2 | <b>Reform Movements</b>                                          | Emulating the pattern of higher Hindu castes; socio-religious reform within tribal society     | Bhagat movement (Oraon); Vaishnavite movement (Bhumij); Kehr movement (Santhals)                |
| 3 | <b>Political Movements</b><br>( <i>Positive Regionalism</i> )    | Post-Independence demands for tribal states within the Indian Union                            | Jharkhand movement (Chotanagpur & Orissa); Hill states movement (Assam & M.P.)                  |
| 4 | <b>Secessionist Movements</b><br>( <i>Negative Regionalism</i> ) | Demands for complete separation / independent nation; rejection of Indian sovereignty          | Naga movement; Mizo movement                                                                    |
| 5 | <b>Agrarian Unrest Movements</b>                                 | Class-based peasant and tribal unrest linked to land alienation; overlap with Naxalism         | Naxalbari movement (1967); Birsadal movement (1968–69)                                          |

**Key Link:** Among these five types, *Political movements* represent the **positive sense of Regionalism**, while *Secessionist movements* represent the **negative sense of**

### 3 Santhal Rebellion (1855–56)

#### Santhal Rebellion (Hul) — 1855–56

**Leaders:** Sido & Kanhu (also written as Kanu and Siddu)

##### Factors / Causes

| Dimension        | Cause                                                                                                                                                                           |
|------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Social</b>    | Introduction of new land ownership system — interfered with traditional collective landholding of Santhals.                                                                     |
| <b>Economic</b>  | High taxes crippled tribals; moneylenders exploited them; many Santhals alienated from their lands.                                                                             |
| <b>Political</b> | Rich landlords spread influence in tribal lands with money power; local officials and British patrons sided with exploiters; courts of law only helped exploiters, not tribals. |

##### Consequence & Outcome

- Under the leadership of **Kanu and Siddu**, Santhals started to rebel.
- Santhals attacked police, moneylenders, and looted what they could.
- The British ordered the army to crush the rebellion — **army suppressed the rebellion**; leaders were arrested.
- **After 1 year the rebellion subsided.**

### 4 Munda Rebellion — Birsa Munda & Ulgulan

## Munda Rebellion (Ulgulan) — 1899–1900

**Leader:** Birsa Munda | **Movement Name:** Ulgulan (Great Tumult)

### Factors / Causes

| Dimension              | Cause                                                                                                                                                                          |
|------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Socio-Religious</b> | Cultural contacts with Hindu royalty → few Mundas adopted Hinduism; others adopted Christianity with false hope, leading to confusion of identity.                             |
| <b>Economic</b>        | Hindu priests donated large portions of land; priests assumed traits of landlords; poor Munda cultivators faced high taxes and lived in extreme poverty.                       |
| <b>Political</b>       | British rulers established dominance; landlords were given the power of police; whenever there was a clash between tribes and landlords, British always sided with exploiters. |

### Consequence & Outcome

- Under the leadership of **Birsa Munda**, around **6,000 Mundas** started to rebel; attacked all outsiders.
- Fierce fighting → Mundas lost; **Birsa was arrested and sent to prison in Ranchi.**
- After release, Birsa led another rebellion — rebels didn't spare Christian Mundas either.
- With army and modern weapons, **Munda rebellion was ultimately crushed.**

### Significance

The settlement and survey operations in Ranchi district took shape *due to this Munda rebellion* — showing how tribal resistance forced colonial administration to reform its policies.

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## 5 Naga Rebellion — Phizo & Greater Nagalim

## Naga Rebellion — 1947 onwards

**Key Leader:** Zapu Phizo | **Organisation:** Naga National Council (NNC)

### Background & Situation

- Nagas are freedom-loving; they do not bow to authority.
- **Charles Pawsey (1945)** planted the idea of seceding from India and forming a separate country.
- Under leadership of Charles Pawsey and Zapu Phizo, declared Nagaland would not be part of independent India (**1947**).
- This separatist tendency aimed to define their socio-cultural identity and fear losing it in the ocean of Hindu nationalism.

### Consequence & Outcome

- Phizo and followers started a rebellion to form a **separate country**.
- Formation of the **State of Nagaland in 1952** was a result of this rebellion.
- The separatist tendency did not end — certain groups still exhibit secessionist tendency under the banner of **Greater Nagalim** (demand for unified Naga homeland across state borders).
- Phizo turned down many offers of negotiated settlement; NNC launched armed struggle for Naga sovereignty.
- Earlier demands: **separate country, national flag and constitution**.
- In recent times: Nagas feel increasingly integral to the nation; some agreements made between Naga people and Government of India → **Naga insurgency was reduced**.

**M. Alemchiba Ao:** The main cause of the Naga conflict is the government's *lack of knowledge of tribal interests and needs*.

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## 6 Mizo Rebellion — MNF, Laldenga & Peace Accord 1986

## Mizo Rebellion — 1954 to 1986

**Key Leader:** Laldenga | **Organisation:** Mizo National Front (MNF)

### Background & Factors

| Dimension                       | Cause                                                                                                                                     |
|---------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Geographic</b>               | Mizos much alienated from rest of India; poor communication links; remoteness bred separateness.                                          |
| <b>Religious</b>                | Christian missionaries converted tribals; this further widened the cultural gap with mainland India.                                      |
| <b>External</b>                 | Fueled by unfriendly countries — China and Pakistan. Some Mizos believed they were never part of British India.                           |
| <b>The Great Famine of 1959</b> | Assam government's <b>failure to respond adequately</b> to the great famine of 1959 in Mizo hills turned popular sentiment against India. |

### Timeline of Events

| Year        | Event                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|-------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>1954</b> | Demand for separate State — <i>Mizoland</i> started                                                                                                                                         |
| <b>1966</b> | MNF launched armed campaign for full independence; two-decade-long battle began; got support from Pakistan, used shelter in East Pakistan; Indian security forces used the <b>Air Force</b> |
| <b>1970</b> | New state of <b>Meghalaya</b> created (part of larger Northeast reorganisation)                                                                                                             |
| <b>1971</b> | <b>Mizoram declared a Union Territory</b>                                                                                                                                                   |
| <b>1986</b> | <b>Peace Accord</b> signed between PM Rajiv Gandhi and Laldenga                                                                                                                             |
| <b>1987</b> | <b>Mizoram granted full statehood</b> ; MNF gave up secessionist struggle; Laldenga became Chief Minister                                                                                   |

### Laldenga (1937–1990)

- Founder and leader of the Mizo National Front.
- Turned into a rebel after the experience of the famine of 1959.
- Led an armed struggle against India for two decades.
- Reached a settlement — **signed an agreement with Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi in 1986.**
- Became the **Chief Minister** of the newly created State of Mizoram.

## Peace Accord 1986 — Key Provisions

- Mizoram was **granted full-fledged statehood** with special powers.
- MNF agreed to **give up secessionist struggle**.
- Laldenga became Chief Minister.
- Today, Mizoram is one of the **most peaceful places in the region** and has taken big strides in literacy and development.

**Significance:** The 3 Tribal Autonomous District Councils in Mizoram have served to protect an otherwise endangered tribal identity — providing a democratic platform for former separatists to become a party of governance, significantly reducing political extremism.

## 7 Reasons for Tribal Discontent

1. **Harsh forest laws and regulations** — e.g., Indian Forest Act, 1927 regulated the rights of tribals over forest land and produce.
2. **Inability of legislation to protect tribal lands**
  - *Chotanagpur Tenancy Act, 1908* — restricts transfer of tribal land to non-tribals.
  - *Santhal Pargana Act, 1949* — does not allow transfer of land even for public purposes like education, medical facilities, skill development, or urbanisation.
3. **Ineffective measures** to rehabilitate tribal population — most rehabilitation remains on paper.
4. **Inadequacy of credit facilities** to combat tribal indebtedness.
  - MP government (2019) waived all loans taken by STs from unlicensed moneylenders through amendment to *Anusuchit Jan Jaati Sahukar Viniyam 1972*.
5. **Delay in implementing recommendations** of high-level bodies — K.S. Singh Committee, Xaxa Committee (2013), Dhebar Commission (1960), Bhuria Commission (2002).

**Key Point:** Tribal rebellion is **not a sudden outburst** of anger but a **result of prolonged socio-economic-political exploitation** that pushed tribals beyond their tolerance limit.

## 8 Political Developments Post-Independence



Post-Independence India was determined to end tribal misery. An **Advisory Committee on Fundamental Rights, Minorities and Tribal and Excluded Areas** was formed, headed by **Sardar Patel**, with the following sub-committees:

| Sub-Committee                                                                                | Head              |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------|
| Minorities Sub-Committee                                                                     | H.C. Mukherjee    |
| North-East Frontier Tribal Areas and Assam Excluded & Partially Excluded Areas Sub-Committee | Gopinath Bardoloi |
| Excluded and Partially Excluded Areas (other than Assam) Sub-Committee                       | A.V. Thakkar      |
| North-West Frontier Tribal Areas Sub-Committee                                               | —                 |

Government made several important political developments: **FRA 2006, Chotanagpur Tenancy Act 1908, Santhal Pargana Act 1949.**

## 9 Regionalism — Concept, Dimensions & Causes

### Definition of Regionalism

**Sulli Mukherjee:** Regionalism is a process of self-determination on linguistic, religious or ethnic lines which *challenges the sovereignty* of a country and hinders nation-building.

**David L. Sills (1968):** Defines a region as "a *homogenous area* with physical and cultural characteristics distinct from those of neighboring areas." The region possesses a sense of identity distinct from the rest of the country — having both territorial reference and socio-cultural and psychological consciousness.

**Core of regionalism:** A profound sense of identity — widely shared sentiment of togetherness and a '**we-feeling**' that often reinforces a sense of separateness. Primarily based on awareness of **linguistic, religious, ethnic and cultural identity** of a particular geographical region.

### Regionalism in Positive Sense

- Inspires people to develop **brotherhood and unity** to protect regional interests and promote welfare.
- Plays an important role in **building the nation** if demands of regions are accommodated by the political system.
- Regional recognition through statehood or state autonomy gives **self-determination** — people feel empowered and happy.

- **Internal self-determination** (linguistic, tribal, religious, regional) has been the predominant form of regionalism in India.
- Regional identities in India have **not always** defined themselves in opposition to national identity — they bring people closer to local and regional governance.
- Balanced regional development; socio-cultural diversity given due respect.
- **Example:** The 3 Tribal Autonomous District Councils in Mizoram protected tribal identity, gave former separatists a democratic platform, and significantly reduced political extremism.

## Regionalism in Negative Sense

- Indicates **excessive attachment to one's region** — a significant threat to national unity and integrity.
- When people identify more strongly with their region than their nation, nationalism is undercut by regionalism.

## Five Reasons for Regionalism in India

| # | Reason                                                 | Example                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|---|--------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 | <b>Economic Backwardness and Exploitation</b>          | Jharkhand — historically part of Bihar; remained underdeveloped despite rich mineral resources; tribal displacement due to mining; lack of representation → <b>Jharkhand state in 2000</b> |
| 2 | <b>Unmet Expectations from the State</b>               | LWE-affected regions of Chhattisgarh, Odisha, Jharkhand, Andhra Pradesh — governance failure and poor service delivery → regional alienation exploited by extremist movements              |
| 3 | <b>Neglect of Local Aspirations</b>                    | Telangana — injustice in water sharing, employment, resource allocation within united Andhra Pradesh → <b>Telangana became a separate state in 2014</b>                                    |
| 4 | <b>Sense of Insecurity and Fear of Domination</b>      | Gorkhaland movement in Darjeeling — fear of cultural and linguistic marginalisation among Nepali-speaking Gorkhas → <b>Gorkhaland Territorial Administration (GTA)</b> formed              |
| 5 | <b>Quest for Self-Identity and Cultural Fulfilment</b> | Kannada Rakshana Vedike (Karnataka); Samyukta Maharashtra Movement (1950s–60s); <b>Dravidian movement in Tamil Nadu</b> opposing Hindi imposition → gave rise to DMK                       |

## 10 Tribes and Regionalism — Key Movements

### A. Jharkhand Movement

**Background:** Jharkhand has tribal population spread over Bihar, West Bengal, Madhya Pradesh, and Orissa. Movement for separate Jharkhand state started in **1939**.

### Three Main Reasons

1. Rampant corruption by government officials → denudation of forest and exploitation.
2. Uncontrolled **land alienation** of tribals.
3. **Underdevelopment and unemployment** of tribals despite setting up many developmental projects in their lands.

### Key Organisations & Outcome

- **Jharkhand Mukti Morcha (JMM)** and **All Jharkhand Students Union (AJSU)** formed to support the movement.
- After decades of agitation, **Jharkhand state was created in 2000**.

**Dr. Ram Dyal Munda** (former VC, Ranchi University): The government took over forests ostensibly to manage them, but gross *mismanagement led to virtual disappearance of forests* — the mainstay of Jharkhand economy. Projects acquired more land than necessary; used for private housing; *original landowners became destitutes*.

## B. Naga Movement

**Leader:** Angami Zaphu Phizo | **Organisation:** Naga National Council (NNC)

- Post-Independence: non-tribal people came in large numbers to settle in Nagaland hills.
- Outsiders' greed → **economic exploitation, alienation and insecurity of Nagas** → separatist movement.
- A section of Nagas declared independence from India in **1951**.
- Phizo turned down many offers of negotiated settlement; NNC launched armed struggle for Naga sovereignty.
- Earlier demands: **separate country, national flag and constitution**.
- Recent times: Nagas feel integral part of the nation; some agreements made → **Naga insurgency was reduced**.

## C. Zeliangrong Movement

**Leaders:** Jadonang & Rani Gaidinliu | **Organisation:** Zeliangrong People's Convention (ZPC)

- Zeliangrongs: a minority tribe spread over Assam, Manipur, and Nagaland.
- United under **Zeliangrong People's Convention (ZPC)** to seek separate states.
- Movement started in the **1930s** when they revolted against the British.
- State government neglected development of Zeliangrong-inhabited areas.
- Struggle led by **Jadonang** and **Rani Gaidinliu**.
- Since inception of ZPC in 1980, they have been demanding integration of Zeliangrong areas into a political unit.
- Movement is largely **free from violent activities** — distinguishing it from Naga and Mizo movements.

#### D. Mizo Movement (detailed under Section 6)

See Section 6 above for full details. Key summary: After Independence, Mizo Hills was made an autonomous district within Assam. Some Mizos believed they were never part of British India. Famine of 1959 + Assam government's failure → formation of MNF under Laldenga → armed rebellion → Peace Accord 1986 → Statehood 1987.

#### Conclusion on Regionalism

**M.N. Srinivas:** Regionalism can never be tackled as merely a *law and order problem* — it should be tackled with *care, sympathy and appreciation of long suppressed tribal aspirations*.

Regionalism is **not only a geographical-political phenomenon** but is a dynamic and multi-dimensional concept encompassing geo-physical, psychological, socio-cultural and politico-economic variables. A country like India must have better appreciation of regional cultures and minimise regional imbalance.

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## 11 Unrest Among Tribal Communities — Naxalism / LWE

### Overview

- Naxalism (Left-Wing Extremism / LWE) is one of the most serious issues in India.
- LWE can be observed in almost all tribal belts.

- Result of decades of **tribal oppression and negligence** from the government.
- The "**jal, jangal, zameen**" that belonged to tribals were openly exploited.
- The tribal voice in response to this exploitation is **Naxalism/LWE**.

**Alpna Sran:** Naxals function like a *parallel government*, enjoying confidence and support of the people of lands they control. To establish themselves as primary law, Naxals start by attacking police and local elites, then 'tax' various economic activities.

## Why Do Tribals Support Naxals?

Adivasis prefer this '**jungle sarkar**' over the Indian state because new arrangements are to their benefit.

**Example — Tendu Leaf Collection:** A key revenue source is the collection and **sale of Tendu leaves** (used to make beedis).

- Earlier, this collection was controlled by **upper-caste elites** who paid low wages and controlled all profits.
- Naxals came, **doubled wages**, and even awarded some contracts to local Adivasi and other impoverished groups.
- Some of the 'tax' they collected was rerouted to **schools, medical camps and clinics** in the region.

## Two Perspectives on Naxalism

| Perspective             | View                                                                                     | Approach                                                            |
|-------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Security-Centric</b> | Naxalism is a <i>threat to national security</i>                                         | Law-and-order solution; military operations                         |
| <b>Socio-Economic</b>   | Naxalism is a <i>socio-economic problem</i> — result of 200 years of tribal exploitation | Development, land rights, FRA implementation, grassroots governance |

## Six Underlying Roots (Problems) Fuelling LWE

### Root 1: Unemployment and Poverty

Post cultural contact (especially colonial period), lack of developmental activities → less employment. Educated tribal youth remain unemployed and poverty-struck → naturally attracted to sympathetic Naxals.

**Example:** In Jharkhand and Chhattisgarh, mining expansion displaced local youth without providing alternative jobs. Many joined Maoist ranks as daily wage opportunities dried up.

**Walter Fernandes (1996):** Described such youth as the "*first victims of displacement and the first recruits for rebellion*" — showing how development without inclusion fuels alienation.

### Root 2: Tribals as "Victims of Progress"

Most developmental projects find their base in forest/tribal lands. Due to these projects, many tribal people are displaced. As per Planning Commission: **not even 20% of these are rehabilitated properly**. Tribals made to suffer as the "sacrificial goat for development."

**Example:** Sardar Sarovar Dam on Narmada displaced thousands of Bhil and Tadvī tribals; only **17%** fully rehabilitated (Planning Commission data).

**Walter Fernandes and Stan (Jebaraj):** Termed this phenomenon *development-induced displacement* — where tribals become sacrificial goats of progress.

### Root 3: Displacement and Forced Evictions

Tribal communities forcibly removed from traditional lands in the name of development of mining, irrigation, and power projects. Acquisition of large tracts of land for "public purposes" without adequate compensation or rehabilitation → major cause of discontent.

**Kalinga Nagar, Odisha (2006):** Land acquisition for a Tata Steel project led to violent protests, leaving **13 tribal protesters dead**. The incident intensified Maoist influence.

#### Root 4: Forest and Livelihood Related Reasons

Inadequate access to forest endangers food security. Disruption of traditional livelihoods and absence of alternative employment. Denial of traditional rights to common property resources.

**Example:** The *Forest Conservation Act (1980)* restricted shifting cultivation and forest produce collection in Bastar, affecting the livelihood of **Muria and Maria Gonds**.

**Roy Burman:** Highlighted that the loss of access to forests severs the *ecological and cultural lifeline* of tribal society, producing alienation and unrest.

#### Root 5: Land Related Reasons

Failure to legally recognise traditional land rights. Poor enforcement of laws that prohibit transfer of tribal land to non-tribals in Fifth Schedule areas. Powerful individuals illegally occupying government and community lands.

**Khammam District, Telangana:** Non-tribals illegally occupied podu (hill) lands despite Fifth Schedule safeguards. FRA 2006 implementation remains **below 40%** in such areas.

**B.D. Sharma:** Argued that land alienation is the *single most powerful cause of tribal discontent*, calling it "the root of their revolt."

#### Root 6: Failing to Implement the Provisions

Many provisions made for betterment of tribals, but implementation is not strict.

**Example:** Despite PESA Act (1996) mandating Gram Sabha consultation in Scheduled Areas, mining leases in **Dantewada and Korba** were granted without tribal consent.

**Xaxa Committee Report (2014):** Observed that the state's neglect of constitutional protections (like PESA and FRA) perpetuates "*structural violence*" against tribal populations.

### Findings & Recommendations — Expert Group (Planning Commission, 2006)

| Recommendation     | Detail                                                            |
|--------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Open Approach      | Recommendation for open approach rather than security-centric one |
| Land's Role in LWE | Emphasis on recognising the pivotal role of land in growth of LWE |

| Recommendation                   | Detail                                                                                           |
|----------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Land Distribution</b>         | Recommendation to ensure landless individuals receive land                                       |
| <b>Better FRA Implementation</b> | Urgent need for improved implementation of Forest Rights Act 2006                                |
| <b>Curbing Power Misuse</b>      | Checking misuse of power by forest and police officials in tribal areas                          |
| <b>Land Acquisition Act</b>      | Emphasis on scrutinising potential misuse of Land Acquisition Act (Eminent Domain)               |
| <b>Corporate Impact</b>          | Recognition of negative impact of MNCs and their projects on tribal and marginalised communities |

## Ways to Deal with Naxal Menace (2006 Union Minister Recommendations)

1. **Serious Actions Against Naxals** — decisive security actions
2. **Inter-State Coordination** — coordinated efforts among states
3. **Discontinuation of Peace Dialogues** (as a strategic measure)
4. **Holistic Policy Formulation** — development and implementation of better holistic policies
5. **Priority Development in Naxal Areas** — prioritised developmental initiatives

## Case Studies on Tribal Unrest

### Case Study 1: Essar and the Maoist-Affected Mining Belt of Chhattisgarh

- A 2010 **WikiLeaks cable** revealed that **Essar Group**, operating mining and steel projects in **Chhattisgarh's Dantewada region**, was compelled to pay "significant amounts" as **protection money to Maoist groups** to ensure safety of its property and staff.
- Demonstrates that even large corporations and MNCs are **helpless under extremist threats**, forced to negotiate for operational survival.

#### Impact on Tribes:

- Industrial-insurgent tensions deepened tribal insecurity.
- Adivasi communities — caught between Maoist coercion and state militarisation — face **displacement, loss of forest access, and erosion of traditional livelihoods**.
- Initiatives like Salwa Judum fractured intra-tribal relations.



## Case Study 2: Salwa Judum and the Supreme Court Verdict (2011)

- Launched in **2005 in Dantewada and Bijapur (Chhattisgarh)**.
- *Salwa Judum* = "peace march" in Gondi language.
- A **state-supported vigilante movement** aimed at mobilising tribal youth against Maoists.
- Government armed them as **Special Police Officers (SPOs)** with minimal training.
- Intended as community defense force → instead led to **widespread violence, displacement, and rights violations**.
- In **2011, the Supreme Court (Justices Sudershan Reddy & Nijjar)** declared the use of SPOs and *Koya Commandos* **illegal and unconstitutional** under **Articles 14 and 21**.

### Impact on Tribes:

- Thousands of Adivasis displaced; villages razed; civilians caught between Maoists and state-backed forces suffered severe trauma.
- Breakdown of trust between tribal communities and the state deepened alienation.
- Verdict reinforced that **counter-insurgency must remain within constitutional limits**.

## Way Forward for Addressing LWE

- Address structural roots of displacement, poverty, and alienation — as emphasised by the **Xaxa Committee (2014)**.
- **Livelihood Initiatives:** Promoting financial independence through self-help groups, access to credit and marketing opportunities.
- **Upgrading Infrastructure:** Developing infrastructure (especially road networks) through specialised government agencies rather than local contractors.
- **Forest Rights Protection:** Effective implementation of FRA 2006. In **Gadchiroli (Maharashtra)**, Gram Sabhas successfully manage bamboo and tendu collection under FRA — shows that recognition of forest rights reduces alienation and Maoist sympathy.

**Elinor Ostrom's** concept of *community-based resource governance* supports localised management as sustainable and conflict-resolving.

*"While LWE/Naxal/Maoist violence is definitely a security issue, it is equally a **political and a development issue**. We will not end this war by bullets alone — we will win it only if we **win over hearts and minds**. This can be done only by enabling conditions for grassroots political mobilisation, improving delivery of development schemes (like FRA), and ensuring*

*fair-benefit sharing of resources — in other words, **bridging the trust deficit.**"*

— Varad Pandey

## 12 Pseudo-Tribalism

### Definition

**Pseudo-tribalism** refers to the phenomenon where **members of a group attempt to create or reinforce a sense of tribal identity**, even if they do not have a **historically legitimate claim** to such an identity.

In the Indian context: certain sections of society try to **label themselves as 'tribals'** to enjoy concessions and privileges in education and employment.

### Criteria for Specification as a Scheduled Tribe (Currently Followed)

1. Indications of **primitive traits**
2. Distinctive **culture**
3. **Geographical isolation**
4. **Shyness of contact** with the community at large
5. **Backwardness**

**Note:** These criteria are *not spelt out in the Constitution* — they have been evolved through committee recommendations (especially the Lokur Committee, 1965).

### Case Studies in Pseudo-Tribalism

### Case Study 1: Gujjars of Rajasthan

- Demanding **5% reservation** under Special Backwards Classes (SBC) category.
- Fight for reservation began in **2006** when Gujjars demanded inclusion in the **Scheduled Tribe (ST)** reservation.
- Gujjars have been covered under **OBC reservation since 1994**.
- After the **Chopra Committee Report** said Gujjars could not be given ST status, the community settled for 5% reservation under a new SBC category.
- But this took total reservation beyond the **50% ceiling** set by the Supreme Court → Rajasthan High Court quashed it.

### Legislative Attempts

- **Vasundhara Raje-led BJP government (2008)** brought a bill for 5% SBC reservation to Gujjars and four other communities (Banjara/Baldia, Labana, Gadia-Lohar/Gadalia, Raika/Rebari, and Gadaria). HC stayed the law (December 22, 2010).
- Government repealed the 2008 Act and introduced a new bill in Assembly in **September 2015**: *Rajasthan Special Backward Classes Bill, 2015*. Rajasthan HC struck it down on **December 9, 2016** (crossed 50% limit).
- Rajasthan government brought a bill in **2017** to raise OBC quota from 21% to 26% — also struck down by HC.

### Leadership

- **Colonel (Retd.) Kirori Singh Bainsla** leading community since 2006 (uprooted railway tracks in Hindaun City, Karauli district); contested 2009 Lok Sabha election on BJP ticket, lost by 317 votes.
- In February 2019, his son **Vijay Singh Bainsla** became deputy.

### Case Study 2: Communities in Assam Demanding ST Status

**Six communities demanding ST status:** Koch-Rajbongshi, Tai-Ahom, Chutia, Matak, Moran, and Tea Tribes.

Groups like *All Assam Tribal Sangha* and *Coordination Committee of Tribal Organisations of Assam* are **opposing the move** — specifically opposing Koch-Rajbongshi and Tai-Ahom, who reigned over large swathes of present-day Assam, Bangladesh, and West Bengal during the medieval period. Their historical dominance makes the claim of tribal marginalisation questionable.

### Case Study 3: Meitei Community of Manipur

- Manipur's **dominant Meitei community wants Scheduled Tribe status**.
- Tribal groups in the state say if Meitei are granted ST status, 'Meitei millionaires' will encroach on their (tribal) land.
- The demand was discussed in the **Manipur Assembly as far back as 1981**.
- Meitei elites (Vaishnav Hindus) historically saw the ST tag as an affront to their status — they had **abandoned the traditional Sanamahi faith** and converted en masse to Hinduism in the late 17th and early 18th century.
- The demand got a new lease of life in **2012** when the Scheduled Tribe Demand Committee wrote memorandums, including to Prime Minister Manmohan Singh.

### Case Study 4: Narikkuravar Community of Tamil Nadu

#### Background

The Narikkuravars are a **nomadic, hunter-gatherer** community in Tamil Nadu, traditionally engaged in **bead-making and hunting**. They have long faced social exclusion, poverty, and low literacy.

#### Earlier Classification

- Earlier listed under **Most Backward Classes (MBC)** in Tamil Nadu.
- Already recognised as **Scheduled Tribe (ST)** in Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh.

#### Demand & Outcome

Due to extreme vulnerability, Tamil Nadu sought ST status for the community. In **2022, the Union Government approved their inclusion** in the ST list.

#### Significance

Ensures **constitutional protection, reservation benefits**, and access to welfare schemes. Recognises their **distinct socio-cultural identity** and addresses long-standing deprivation.

*Note: Unlike the other three case studies, the Narikkuravar case is considered a **legitimate inclusion** (not pseudo-tribalism) — it is discussed alongside the others as a contrast case.*

## Impact of Granting ST Status to Non-Tribal Groups

1. **Dilution of Benefits** — reduces access to education, employment, and political representation for genuine STs (from Gram Sabha to Lok Sabha).

2. **Further Marginalisation** — already deprived tribal groups risk becoming further marginalised as competition increases.
3. **Distortion of Policy Purpose** — original aim of affirmative action is to uplift historically isolated and indigenous groups; extending ST recognition to non-tribals **undermines constitutional intent**.
4. **Erosion of Tribal Identity** — blurs the distinct cultural and ethnographic identity of indigenous tribes, weakening their social recognition and collective agency.
5. **Political Manipulation** — ST recognition demands often driven by **vote-bank politics**, not genuine socio-anthropological need.
6. **Administrative Complexity** — frequent additions make monitoring and implementation of welfare schemes difficult.
7. **Violation of Ethnographic Criteria** — as per the **Lokur Committee (1965)**, ST identification must rest on traits like distinct culture, geographical isolation, and social backwardness. Inclusion of non-tribals **breaches this anthropological basis**.
8. **Social Tensions** — may trigger **resentment and inter-group conflicts**, particularly in ethnically sensitive states like Assam and Tripura.

## Way Forward (Pseudo-Tribalism)

- **Strengthen ST identification criteria:** Implement clear, objective benchmarks based on social, economic, and cultural indicators (not solely historical narratives). Consider poverty levels, educational attainment, lack of land rights.
- **Invest in alternative development initiatives:** Focus on targeted programs — skill development, healthcare access, livelihood creation — so communities don't solely rely on reservation benefits.

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## 13 Youth Dormitories

### Introduction

Youth dormitories are found in all parts of the world where tribals reside. They have specific **functions, rules, and beliefs** associated with them. This is the place where eligible youth gather in the evening for social, economic, and cultural activities.

**Malinowski (1929):** Finest example is the *Bukumatula* of Trobriand Islanders — mentioned in his book "*The Sexual Life of Savages in North-Western Melanesia*."

### Types of Youth Dormitories (Majumdar's Classification)

**Majumdar** did an extensive study on youth dormitories in India; describes both **mono-sexual** and **bisexual** youth dormitories.

| Tribe                  | Dormitory Name    | Type        |
|------------------------|-------------------|-------------|
| Konyak Nagas (Boys)    | <b>Ban</b>        | Mono-sexual |
| Konyak Nagas (Girls)   | <b>Yo</b>         | Mono-sexual |
| Oraons                 | <b>Dhumkuriya</b> | Bi-sexual   |
| Murias/Gonds of Bastar | <b>Ghotul</b>     | Bi-sexual   |
| Ho tribe               | <b>Giitora</b>    | —           |
| Munda (Jharkhand)      | —                 | —           |
| Nagaland tribes        | <b>Morung</b>     | —           |

## Origin of Youth Dormitories (Controversial)

| Scholar               | View on Origin                                                                                                                                                                                         |
|-----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Hodson</b>         | Youth dormitories may be a "survival" of communal houses, designed to promote community living and sharing of resources.                                                                               |
| <b>Grigson</b>        | Study of Hill Marias suggests traditional societies did not view the home as appropriate for sexual activity; dormitories were designed to <b>separate sexual activity from the home environment</b> . |
| Other anthropologists | Dormitories were designed to <b>prevent incest</b> — highlighting importance of avoiding close familial relationships.                                                                                 |
| Some scholars         | Dormitories intended to <b>protect children from witnessing sexual activity</b> , which could potentially traumatise them.                                                                             |

## Location

Dormitories are specially built buildings usually situated in the **outskirts of the village** so members can carry out activities without any disturbance.

## Functions of Youth Dormitories

### S.C. Roy — Three-fold Purpose Among Oraons:

1. As the **economic organisation** for the food quest.
2. For training young men in their **social and other duties**.
3. As a place for performance of **magico-religious ceremonies**.

### Singh — Functions Among Gonds:

1. For **joint economic pursuits**.
2. Training in **social and sexual behavior**.
3. For **accommodation**.

## Seven Factors for the Decline of Youth Dormitories

| # | Factor                                                     | Detail & Example                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
|---|------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 | <b>Cultural Contact &amp; Religious Conversion</b>         | Missionaries criticised dormitories as "immoral" or "heathen" institutions. <b>Example:</b> Among Murias and Gonds of Bastar, missionaries actively discouraged the <i>ghotul</i> , leading to its disuse in several villages.                                                                                                                                  |
| 2 | <b>Influence of Modern Education</b>                       | Formal schooling replaced traditional modes of youth education. Western education shifted training from community to State-controlled institutions. <b>Verrier Elwin (1947):</b> Spread of modern schools led to neglect of the <i>ghotul</i> and <i>dhumkuria</i> .                                                                                            |
| 3 | <b>Urbanisation and Migration</b>                          | Young people migrating for labour or education found little relevance in dormitory-based communal living. <b>Example:</b> Ho and Munda youth in Jharkhand increasingly moved to nearby towns, leaving behind village dormitory traditions like <i>giitora</i> .                                                                                                 |
| 4 | <b>Loss of Autonomy &amp; Cultural Inferiority Complex</b> | Tribal values were mocked by outsiders and portrayed as "primitive." Many tribals internalised this stigma. <b>Example:</b> The Ho tribes now <i>deny the existence of the giitora</i> under social pressure to appear "modern."                                                                                                                                |
| 5 | <b>Development Projects &amp; Displacement</b>             | Construction of dams, mines, industries led to large-scale displacement. Resettlement areas lacked the social and ecological setting needed for collective institutions. <b>Example:</b> Displacement caused by <i>Hirakud Dam and Rourkela Steel Plant</i> fragmented tribal communities and disrupted institutions like the <i>ghotul</i> and <i>morung</i> . |
| 6 | <b>Governmental &amp; Administrative Neglect</b>           | State policies emphasised welfare schemes, not cultural preservation. No institutional support to revive or integrate dormitory traditions into modern tribal education.                                                                                                                                                                                        |

| # | Factor                              | Detail & Example                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|---|-------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 7 | <b>Change in Economic Structure</b> | Transition from subsistence economy to cash economy reduced community interdependence. With individuals earning wages outside the village, the <b>collective labour and social training functions</b> of the dormitory weakened. |

## Conclusion on Youth Dormitories

*"It seems that this institution is **breathing its last**. In several villages the only thing left in the name of Dhumkuriya is a dilapidated and neglected house standing as a memorial to a great social institution of tribal folks."*

— Sachidananda (who studied central Indian tribes)

## 14 Scholar Quick-Reference, Acts, Committees & UPSC Questions

### All Scholars at a Glance

| Scholar                                      | Key Argument / Contribution                                                               |
|----------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| John Hutchinson & Anthony D. Smith           | 6 connotations of ethnicity                                                               |
| Edward Shils (1957) & Clifford Geertz (1961) | Primordial approach to ethnicity                                                          |
| Paul Brass (1991), Ted Gurr, Abner Cohen     | Instrumentalist approach to ethnicity                                                     |
| Carsten Wieland                              | Situated Primordial approach to ethnicity                                                 |
| Surajit Sinha (1972)                         | Five types of tribal movements                                                            |
| M. Alemchiba Ao                              | Government's lack of knowledge as cause of Naga conflict                                  |
| Sulli Mukherjee                              | Regionalism as self-determination on linguistic/religious/ethnic lines                    |
| David L. Sills (1968)                        | Definition of region as a homogenous area                                                 |
| M.N. Srinivas                                | Regionalism cannot be tackled as a law and order problem                                  |
| Dr. Ram Dyal Munda                           | Forest mismanagement leading to Jharkhand movement; original landowners became destitutes |



| Scholar                 | Key Argument / Contribution                                                                  |
|-------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Alpna Sran              | Naxals function like a parallel government                                                   |
| Walter Fernandes (1996) | Tribal youth = first victims of displacement and first recruits for rebellion                |
| B.D. Sharma             | Land alienation = single most powerful cause of tribal discontent; "root of their revolt"    |
| Roy Burman              | Loss of forest access severs ecological and cultural lifeline of tribal society              |
| Varad Pandey            | LWE is a security + political + development issue; win hearts and minds                      |
| Elinor Ostrom           | Community-based resource governance — sustainable and conflict-resolving                     |
| Xaxa Committee (2014)   | State's neglect of PESA and FRA perpetuates "structural violence" against tribal populations |
| Lokur Committee (1965)  | ST identification must rest on distinct culture, geographical isolation, social backwardness |
| Malinowski (1929)       | Bukumatula of Trobriand Islanders — "Sexual Life of Savages in North-Western Melanesia"      |
| Majumdar                | Extensive study of youth dormitories in India; mono-sexual and bi-sexual types               |
| Hodson                  | Youth dormitories as survival of communal houses                                             |
| Grigson                 | Dormitories to separate sexual activity from home (study of Hill Marias)                     |
| S.C. Roy                | Three-fold purpose of dormitory among Oraons                                                 |
| Singh                   | Purpose of dormitory among Gonds                                                             |
| Verrier Elwin (1947)    | Modern schools led to neglect of ghotul and dhumkuria                                        |
| Sachidananda            | Youth dormitories "breathing its last"                                                       |

## Important Acts & Policies

| Act / Policy      | Year | Significance                                             |
|-------------------|------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| Indian Forest Act | 1927 | Regulated rights of tribals over forest land and produce |

| Act / Policy                                       | Year        | Significance                                                                                            |
|----------------------------------------------------|-------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Chotanagpur Tenancy Act                            | 1908        | Restricts transfer of tribal land to non-tribals (Jharkhand)                                            |
| Santhal Pargana Act                                | 1949        | Does not allow transfer of land even for public purposes                                                |
| Forest Conservation Act                            | 1980        | Restricted shifting cultivation and forest produce collection; affected Muria and Maria Gonds in Bastar |
| PESA Act                                           | 1996        | Mandates Gram Sabha consultation in Scheduled Areas; violated in Dantewada and Korba                    |
| Forest Rights Act (FRA)                            | 2006        | Recognition of forest rights of STs and other traditional forest dwellers                               |
| Anusuchit Jan Jaati Sahukar Viniyam (MP amendment) | 1972 / 2019 | MP amendment (2019) waived all loans taken by STs from unlicensed moneylenders                          |
| Rajasthan Special Backward Classes Bill            | 2015        | 5% SBC reservation to Gujjars and four communities — struck down by HC (crossed 50% ceiling)            |

## Important Committees

| Committee                                         | Year      | Key Significance                                                                                   |
|---------------------------------------------------|-----------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Advisory Committee on Tribal Areas (Sardar Patel) | CA period | Sub-committees under Mukherjee, Bardoloi, A.V. Thakkar                                             |
| Dhebar Commission                                 | 1960      | Tribal welfare recommendations                                                                     |
| Lokur Committee                                   | 1965      | Criteria for ST identification (5 traits); widely followed standard                                |
| K.S. Singh Committee                              | —         | Tribal welfare recommendations                                                                     |
| Expert Group (Planning Commission)                | 2006      | LWE — open approach, land distribution, FRA implementation                                         |
| Xaxa Committee                                    | 2013–14   | Structural violence against tribal populations; comprehensive tribal welfare; PESA and FRA neglect |
| Chopra Committee                                  | —         | Concluded Gujjars could not be given ST status                                                     |
| Bhuria Commission                                 | 2002      | Tribal welfare recommendations                                                                     |

## 15 Probable UPSC Questions

1. What is ethnicity? Discuss the three perspectives to explain ethnicity with reference to Primordial, Instrumentalist, and Situated Primordial approaches.
2. Critically examine Surajit Sinha's five types of tribal movements. How do Political and Secessionist movements relate to Regionalism?
3. Discuss the causes and consequences of the Santhal Rebellion. How did colonial policies lead to tribal discontent?
4. Critically analyse the Munda Rebellion. What role did Birsa Munda play in tribal resistance?
5. Examine the Naga and Mizo rebellions as examples of secessionist movements. How were they resolved or managed?
6. What are the reasons for tribal discontent in India? Discuss relevant legislation and committees.
7. What is Regionalism? Discuss its positive and negative dimensions with examples from India.
8. Critically examine the Jharkhand movement as an example of tribal regionalism.
9. Analyse the Zeliangrong and Mizo movements as examples of tribal regionalism in North-East India.
10. Examine the role of Naxalism as an expression of tribal unrest. What are the structural causes and what is the way forward?
11. Critically examine the concept of Pseudo-tribalism with examples. What are its impacts on genuine STs?
12. Write a note on Youth Dormitories — their types, functions, and factors leading to their decline.
13. "Salwa Judum highlighted the dilemma between tribal welfare and counter-insurgency." Critically examine with reference to the Supreme Court verdict.
14. B.D. Sharma argued that land alienation is the single most powerful cause of tribal discontent. Critically evaluate this statement.
15. Examine Varad Pandey's argument that LWE is as much a political and development issue as it is a security issue.